

Lesson 11

Self-Compassion - Why Being Hard on Yourself Keeps You Stuck

You can do everything right. You can stop reacting. You can build distress tolerance, practice acceptance, allow sensations to be there and still be incredibly hard on yourself the whole time. And that really matters because the way you treat yourself is part of what got you here. We don't get to this place of sensitization on accident.

A lot of us got here because of pain in our past. Difficult childhoods trauma, years of being hard on ourselves, pushing through, ignoring our own needs. Often the way that you talk to yourself now, the harshness, the criticism, the frustration judgment, it is modeled after how you were spoken to or how you were treated earlier in your life, and being hard on yourself is not just something that's unhelpful for healing.

It's part of what contributed to you being in this position in the first place. So when I talk about self-compassion, I'm not talking about something that's like. Soft and fluffy and and whatever. It's not something that's just nice to have. I am talking about addressing one of the root patterns that keeps this stuff alive.

Self-compassion does not mean that you're just constantly letting yourself off the hook or being lazy or making excuses, which people seem to be confused about that all the time. It just, it feels like this softness of doing nothing for me through this process. Self-compassion was like. I'm gonna see this whole thing through.

It was giving it everything I had to give. It was doing the hard work, but it was doing it because I loved myself, not because I hated myself. A lot of this felt like I was doing it for that younger version of me, the part of me that had been through so much and really at this point deserved to finally feel okay.

So self-compassion was not about going easy on myself, but it was about not beating myself up when things were really, really hard. There were days where I felt like things were hard because of me. Or because of some mistake that I made, or if I reacted in a way that I promised myself, I wouldn't. And those were the moments where I had to take my own hand and tell myself, this is gonna be tough, but we're gonna get through it together.

It was when I decided to stop the self abandonment. When you are critical of yourself and frustrated with your progress, your nervous system registers that as a threat. Self-criticism in and of itself is activating. And it contributes to putting you and your nervous system and your body in a state of

tension.

It's like having someone follow you around all day telling you you're doing it wrong. And unfortunately that's someone who's you, your nervous system is gonna read that internal attack as dangerous. So even if from the outside it looks like you're doing all of the right things, if you're doing it from a place that is driven by self-hatred and judgment, you are undermining the work that you're doing.

You are going to react. Sometimes you are going to have days where you go back to old patterns, you're gonna mess up. And when this happens, that's a moment of choice for you. You can pile shame and guilt on top of everything. Tell yourself like, I can't believe I did that again. I'm never gonna get better.

This is never gonna work. What is wrong with me? Or you can meet yourself in those moments with compassion, you can acknowledge what happened. You can notice you reacted in a way that you didn't prefer, in a way that was automatic and in a way where either the pain or the fear or the symptoms really just took over and then you can move on without making it into a whole thing.

Here's what I need you to understand. You do not want shame and guilt driving this ship. If shame and guilt are what is motivating you, you're not healing the root. You're just going to find yourself in another situation like this further down the line, because these are the behavior patterns that keep this stuff alive.

Shame keeps the cycle going, whereas compassion is what breaks it when you mess up. The practice is simple. Notice it. Don't pile any judgment or frustration on top and just start again. No drama. Just start again. There is a difference between pushing yourself harshly and then caring for yourself while you do hard things.

Pushing is like, get over it. Stop being weak. You, you should be better by now. Get it together. But when you're caring for yourself and being compassionate with yourself, it's gonna sound like, yeah, this is really hard and I'm doing it anyway and I'm proud of myself. I'm gonna keep going. I'm gonna keep being kind to myself while I do.

Both of them may look. The same from the outside, like you're doing something hard either way, but the internal experience is what is completely different. And reminder, again, your nervous system knows that difference. You can do things that are really challenging and be gentle with yourself at the same time.

That's actually the only sustainable way to do this. On the really hard days, this matters even more because those are the days where you're most likely to turn on yourself, to be frustrated and to feel like you are failing at this process. And on those days, the practice is to soften toward yourself.

Acknowledge it like today is hard. Lower your expectations if you need to do less, if you need to, and don't make any of that mean something about you or your progress or your worth. A hard day is just a hard day, like learn to let it be that. It does not mean you're going backward, and it doesn't mean that

it's not working.

This is part of soft regulation. Everything I teach in this course is soft. It's not easy. It's soft, it's non-aggressive. It's non-combat, and that includes how you treat yourself. You cannot fight your way to a calm, nervous system. You cannot hate yourself into healing. The softness has to extend to how you treat yourself, how you talk to yourself on bad days, and how you respond when things don't go the way you wanted them to go.

It's all part of the work. Self-compassion is not a nice bonus with all of this. It's essential. It must be included. You are asking yourself to do really hard things, feel discomfort without reacting. Allow sensations to be there, reenter life before you feel better, and you can't do all of that sustainably while also beating yourself up.

Do this because you love yourself. Do this because you know you deserve it. Do it for the younger version of you who's been through so much. Do it because you deserve to finally feel. Okay. In the next lesson, we're gonna talk about what it looks like to actually reenter your life, to give yourself permission to live even while you're still symptomatic.